Independent Hands and Musical Voices

Held notes, different touches, moving bass and compact hymn textures.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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2. Different touches in each hand
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4. Melody with supporting harmony
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6. The Doxology: supporting voices
7. All Hail the Power of Jesus' Name: opening study
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1. Hold one voice while another moves

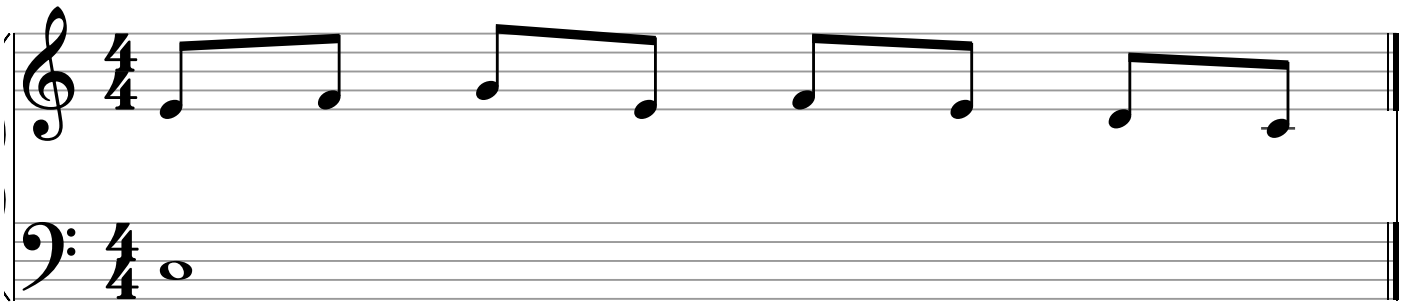
Notice which notes must continue sounding.

Hold one voice while another moves

A voice is a musical line, even when one hand plays more than one line. Begin with the hands separated: one holds while the other moves. Before releasing, check whether that particular voice has finished. Pedal can hide early releases, so first practise without it.

Practise · A held bass line

Keep the bass down until its written change.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A held upper line

Keep the right-hand G held while the left hand walks.

Listen and check

Listen for a sudden hole in the long line. Practise releasing the moving hand without disturbing the held hand.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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2. Different touches in each hand

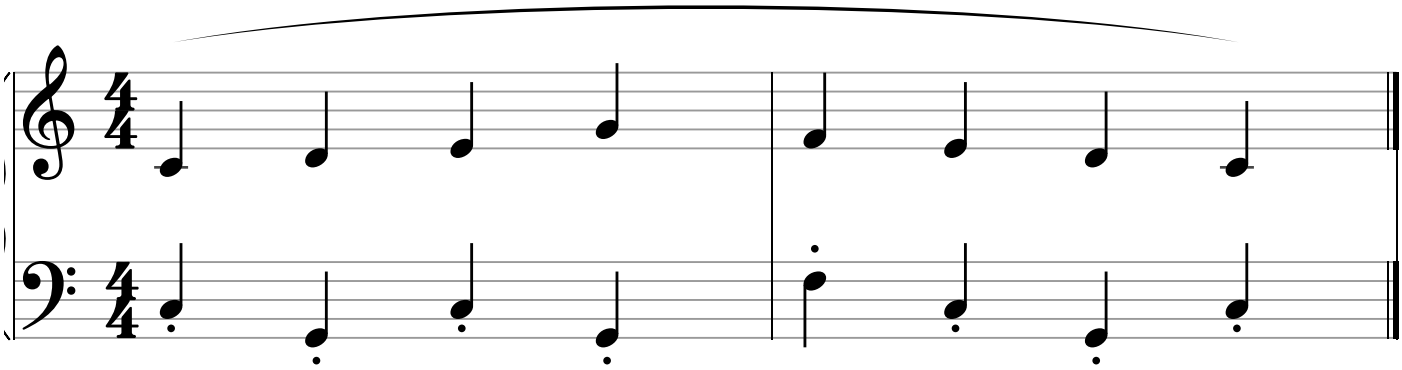
Connect one line while the other is detached.

Different touches in each hand

The two hands can have different jobs. Practise each touch alone, then combine only one bar. Aim for a connected melody over a gently detached accompaniment. Avoid a large wrist bounce in one hand that shakes the other hand out of its phrase.

Practise · Smooth melody, short bass

Keep the right hand connected and make the bass light.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Swap the task

The left-hand line sings while the upper notes release lightly.

Listen and check

Could you hear two different touches? If both hands copy the same articulation, combine just the first two beats until the jobs feel independent.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

3. A bass line with direction

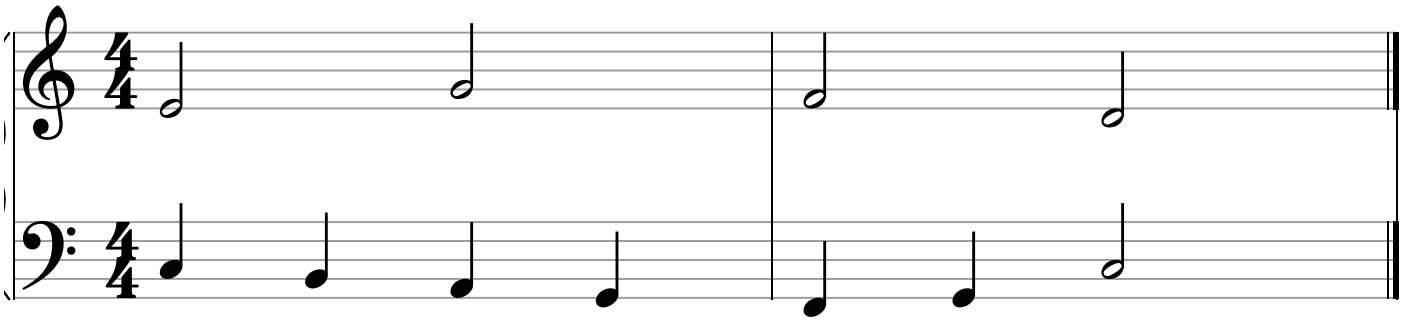
Give the lowest line its own shape.

A bass line with direction

A bass line can travel toward the next harmony instead of jumping between roots. Name its direction and listen for steps that connect the chords. Keep the bass clear but below the melody in volume. A passing bass note does not always mean a completely new chord.

Practise · A descending line

Keep the upper melody clear while the bass steps down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Approach the cadence

Let the bass walk toward G before returning home.

Listen and check

Play and sing only the bass. Then add the melody without making the bass sound like an unrelated exercise.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

4. Melody with supporting harmony

Keep the upper note audible in a two-note right hand.

Melody with supporting harmony

A right-hand chord can contain a melody on top and a quiet supporting note beneath it. Practise only the top notes first. Add the lower notes softly while keeping the top line easy to sing. The paired notes below share a rhythm; later independent inner voices require more specialised notation and practice.

Practise · A singing top note

Hear E-F-G-E as the melody, not a sequence of equally loud blocks.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Add a quiet foundation

Keep the right-hand top line above both supporting parts.

Listen and check

If the melody disappears, remove the lower right-hand note and rebuild. Do not try to solve the balance by making every note louder.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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5. Read a manageable hymn texture

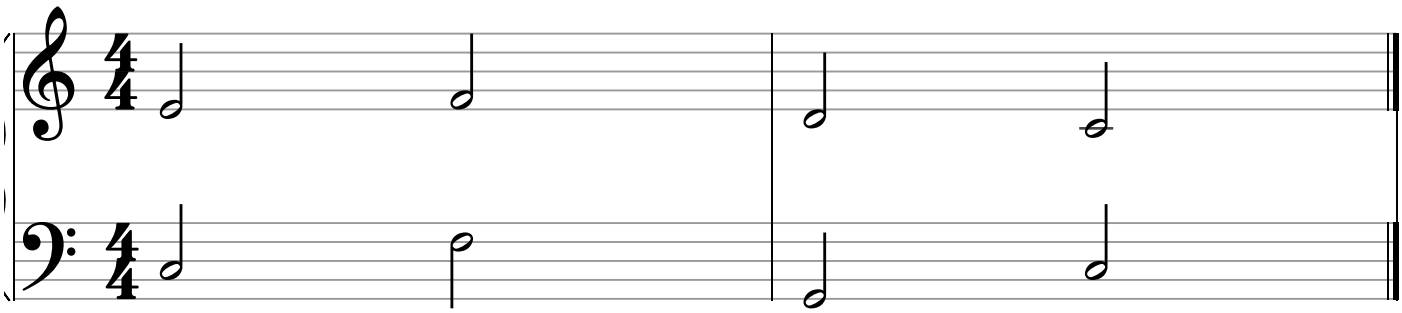
Reduce a chord before making a difficult stretch.

Read a manageable hymn texture

A printed hymn often contains four singing parts. A pianist may redistribute or omit a doubled note while keeping the melody, essential harmony and bass. Read the outer lines first, then add supporting tones. Do not force octaves or large chords; a comfortable reduction is musically useful.

Practise · Outer voices first

Hear the tune above the bass before adding inner tones.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A compact hymn texture

Add supporting harmony without changing the outer lines.

Listen and check

Name the melody and bass in the recital score. If a chord is uncomfortable, keep the top melody and lowest bass and omit a doubled supporting tone during offline practice.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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6. The Doxology: supporting voices

Read the outer lines first, then add the left-hand chord tones softly.

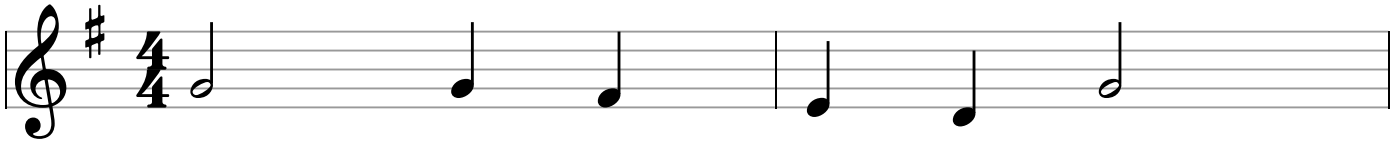
What to listen for

Read the outer lines first, then add the left-hand chord tones softly.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Read the outer lines first, then add the left-hand chord tones softly.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Read the outer lines first, then add the left-hand chord tones softly.

Practise · The Doxology: supporting voices

Read the outer lines first, then add the left-hand chord tones softly.

Your musical check

Identify which tones belong to the melody and which support its harmony.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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7. All Hail the Power of Jesus' Name: opening study

Play the source-checked opening with a clear pickup. Let the bass travel under repeated melody

notes.
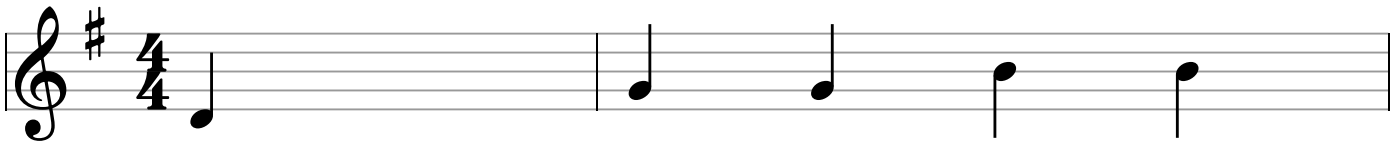
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Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

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Play the source-checked opening with a clear pickup. Let the bass travel under repeated melody notes.

Practise · All Hail the Power of Jesus' Name: opening study

Play the source-checked opening with a clear pickup. Let the bass travel under repeated melody notes.

Your musical check

Play the bass alone and listen to its direction, then restore the melody.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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8. Crown Him with Many Crowns

Keep the melody above the compact supporting chords. This teaching edition halves the source note values and re-bars the changing source metres in 4/4 without changing note-length

proportions.

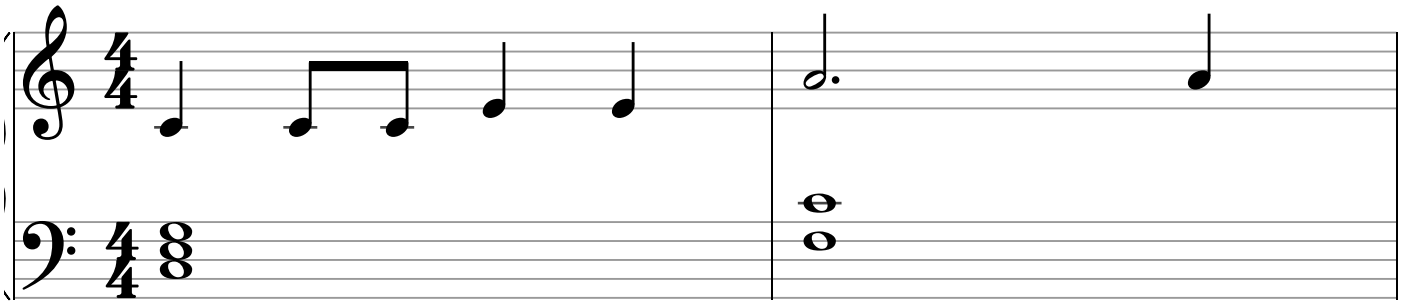
Prepare your recital

Keep the melody above the compact supporting chords. This teaching edition halves the source note values and re-bars the changing source metres in 4/4 without changing note-length proportions.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Crown Him with Many Crowns

Keep the melody above the compact supporting chords. This teaching edition halves the source note values and re-bars the changing source metres in 4/4 without changing note-length proportions.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Keep the melody above the compact supporting chords. This teaching edition halves the source note values and re-bars the changing source metres in 4/4 without changing note-length proportions.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- [ ] Notice which notes must continue sounding.
- [ ] Connect one line while the other is detached.
- [ ] Give the lowest line its own shape.
- [ ] Keep the upper note audible in a two-note right hand.
- [ ] Reduce a chord before making a difficult stretch.
- [ ] Keep the melody above the compact supporting chords. This teaching edition halves the source note values and re-bars the changing source metres in 4/4 without changing note-length proportions.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
